

# “It’s The Same Conflict Every Time, On Repeat.”

## How Digital Technology Use Can Contribute Towards Conflict in Parents’ Relationships

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### ABSTRACT

Family technology use can create or amplify conflict in parents’ relationships – we found four key factors that contribute to this issue. We conducted a probe and interview study with eight sets of parents, to explore how and why technology use might cause conflict in their relationships. This paper presents data from two particular sets of parents to illustrate our findings. In doing so, it complements existing work that primarily focuses on parent-child relationships, and contributes to a more complete understanding of how family technology use can affect family dynamics. We also suggest directions for further work to address this issue of conflict between parents, associated with their family’s use of technology.

### CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); Empirical studies in HCI.

### KEYWORDS

Parents, Parenting, Conflict, Technology, Family, Children, Relationships

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## 1 INTRODUCTION

Digital technology use has become an integral part of the lives of children and parents. As such, many in HCI have been interested in exploring how technology use can impact family dynamics [7, 26]. Researchers have found that managing pervasive technology use within families can be a considerable source of stress for parents and contribute towards tension and family conflict [17, 29]. Substantial research reveal conflict in parent-child relationships; arising primarily from parents’ attempts to mediate their children’s technology use [8, 16, 18]. Recent work also indicate that conflict in family can result from children’s disapproval of how their own parents

use technology [16, 23]. On the other hand, very little research has explored how family technology use can foster conflict in parents’ relationships. This is despite recent indications that conflict can arise between parents when they have differing expectations, either of how one should manage children’s technology use or how one another uses technology at home [1, 11, 24]. Furthermore, conflict (over technology) between parents has been linked to lower overall relationship satisfaction and perceptions of less parenting support [24]. Yet, we lack more nuanced understandings of how and why technology use within families might negatively affect relationships between parents.

We conducted a two-week probe and interview study to explore how family technology use affects the dynamics between eight sets of parents with at least one child under 12 years old. This paper reports on the data from two particular sets of parents. This is because data from these two families were found to exemplify the ways in which technology use can foster tension and conflict in the relationships of all the other parents in our study. We found four key factors that enabled technology use to foster conflict, or to amplify existing conflict, between parents. They are: (i) *differing parenting values*, (ii) *misperceptions*, (iii) *imbalance* and (iv) *inconsistency*. We describe how this conflict can play out between parents within everyday family life. In doing so, we provide a more nuanced understanding of the ways in which technology use can lead to conflict within families. We also discuss directions of future work that would help designers of future domestic technologies to address the conflict that parents associate with technology use.

## 2 RELATED WORK

We discuss two areas of related work within HCI that investigate ways whereby technology use can contribute towards tension and family conflict: (i) efforts to understand parents’ attitudes towards their children’s use of technology, and how conflict can arise from their attempts to mediate (ii) efforts to understand how conflict can arise from parents using technology themselves.

### 2.1 Family Conflict: Parenting Children’s Technology Use

Managing children’s technology use at home is an increasingly complex endeavor and can present a significant source of stress for parents [10, 20, 34]. Many have described how parents’ efforts to mediate children’s technology use can lead to tension and conflict within parent-child relationships [8, 18, 31, 33]. For instance, when parents try to limit children’s exposure to screen-based devices [18, 30], when parents try to work out what their children are using personal devices for, especially online [8, 34], or when parents try to maintain authority when engaging with voice-activated speakers [15, 28]. Studies have described how conflicts can arise when

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parents and children have different expectations as to how much, when and what kind of technology use is appropriate [8, 9, 16]. When children reject, or are found to have broken technology use rules, disagreements abound.

Further work has suggested that parents' experiences of mediating children's technology use is highly nuanced and that their different approaches depend on the particular complexities and dynamics of individual families [22]. The individual approaches of parents can also vary; suggesting that tension and conflict can arise between parents when their individual attitudes on how to manage children's technology use don't align [11]. But technology use has also become more pervasive in the lives of parents themselves [6, 25, 27, 32].

## 2.2 Family Conflict: Parents' Use of Technology

Parents turn to technology to support their parenting goals and to fulfill their individual needs [6, 25, 27, 32]. However, parents must also consider how much time and attention they are giving to their digital devices, especially when spending time with their children [17, 35]. They must also consider how family members might feel about particular aspects of their technology use, such as privacy [1]. For many parents, the challenge is trying to manage their own use of technology, at the same time as attempting to mediate their children's use of technology [8, 11, 27]. This can lead to tension and conflict within families especially when parents struggle to adhere to the rules around technology use that they themselves have established for their family [1, 11, 17, 19].

Tension and conflict can cause parent-child relationships to suffer when children disapprove of their parents' inability to stick to their own rules around family technology use [16, 23]. However, there are also suggestions that the relationship between parents can suffer when one parent's technology use is perceived by the other parent as undermining family technology rules, setting a bad example for children or disrupting family interaction and communication [1, 11, 24]. A recent survey of over 400 participants suggests that parents' use of technology can create conflict between them, and in turn, negatively impact on their overall relationship satisfaction on perceptions of how supported they are in raising their children together [24]. The authors of this study recommend further qualitative research to try and understand how and why parents' use of technology can actually contribute towards such conflict in their relationships [24]. Our study addresses this gap in our understanding of how and why family technology use can contribute towards tension and conflict in the relationships of parents who are raising children together.

## 3 METHOD

Our two-week probe and interview study was designed to tease apart the individual attitudes towards family technology use that exist within sets of parents. We recruited eight sets of parents (with at least one child under 12 years old) to participate in our study (see Table 1). Our collection of three probes offered each set of parents opportunities for individual as well as shared responses. It also prompted parents to reflect on both positive and negative aspects of their family's technology use. We conducted joint, semi-structured, opening interviews with each set of parents in which

we introduced our probe collection. We later held individual, semi-structured, closing interviews with each parent, to discuss their probe responses in private. We clearly informed parents about which responses would be shared with the other, and which would be kept private. This study was conducted with ethics approval from the University of Technology Sydney. For more information on our method, particularly the design of our probe collection, see [12–14].

## 3.1 Data Collection and Analysis

We audio-recorded interviews and took handwritten notes to support our thematic analysis of these data. Next, we draw on the responses of two particular set of parents, to exemplify the ways in which technology use can generate experiences of conflict and tension within sets of parents, and how this can play out within everyday life.

## 4 FINDINGS

We focus our reporting on two of our eight sets of parents, because their experiences are good exemplars and representative of experiences reported by the other parents who took part in our study. We found 4 key factors whereby technology use fostered conflict, or amplified existing conflict, within parents' relationships. First, (Section 4.1) reports on our findings from P9 and P10 to explain how (i) *differing parenting values* and (ii) *misperceptions* enable aspects of family technology use to create tension in their relationship. Next (Section 4.2), we report on our findings from P7 and P8 to describe how (iii) *imbalance* and (iv) *inconsistency* allow family technology use to create conflict between them.

### 4.1 Differing Values and Misperceptions:

P9 (47yrs) and P10 (45yrs) are a married couple raising their son (6yrs) and daughter (2yrs). They described home life as busy, even chaotic; shaped mostly by the needs of their children and their work. P10, a lawyer, works full-time, and often during evenings and weekends at very little notice. Meanwhile, P9, who had just returned to a full-time position in IT has shorter, more regular working hours. She is relied upon as the children's more primary caregiver.

Of all our participants, P9 and P10 were the most explicit about the ways in which technology use contributed to family conflict. They were particularly candid about how aspects of technology use created ongoing disagreements between them. We found that the main factors that led to conflict between P9 and P10 are their *differing parenting values*, and *misperceptions* about one another's attitudes, regarding their family's technology use. As we will show, these two factors play out in a variety of ways, within this set of parents' day-to-day life.

**Differing Parenting Values:** We found that P9 and P10 had different values regarding the use of digital technology within the family, which contributed to persistent conflict between them. A major difference, that frequently triggers conflict, relates to using screen-based devices to placate or entertain children. P10's view on children's technology use was "*I'm generally more negative...I just don't like it very much*" (P10). Meanwhile, P9 said "*I like the convenience of it*" but "*it drives P10 nuts that I'm so lenient when it*

**Table 1: Participants**

| Sets of Parents | Age | Cultural Background | No. of Kids (Age)    |
|-----------------|-----|---------------------|----------------------|
| 1: P1 (Mother)  | 46  | Indonesian          | 2 (9yrs, 7yrs)       |
| P2 (Father)     | 52  | British Indian      |                      |
| 2: P3 (Mother)  | 36  | Japanese            | 3 (7yrs, 5yrs, 3yrs) |
| P4 (Father)     | 38  | French              |                      |
| 3: P5 (Mother)  | 42  | Indonesian          | 3 (7yrs, 5yrs, 3mos) |
| P6 (Father)     | 48  | Australian          |                      |
| 4: P7 (Mother)  | 39  | Iraqi               | 2 (15yrs, 3yrs)      |
| P8 (Father)     | 42  | Iraqi               |                      |
| 5: P9 (Mother)  | 47  | Vietnamese          | 2 (5yrs, 3yrs)       |
| P10 (Mother)    | 45  | Australian          |                      |
| 6: P11 (Mother) | 34  | British             | 2 (6yrs, 2yrs)       |
| P12 (Father)    | 36  | Spanish             |                      |
| 7: P13 (Mother) | 48  | Australian          | 1 (6yrs)             |
| P14 (Father)    | 51  | Australian          |                      |
| 8: P15 (Mother) | 41  | Australian          | 3 (9yrs, 7yrs, 5yrs) |
| P16 (Grandma)   | 74  | Australian          |                      |
| P17 (Aunt)      | 44  | Australian          |                      |

comes to the screens. . . and it's the same conflict every time, on repeat." (P9). P10 concurred "It's just the same old arguments, an ongoing struggle really. The parenting challenge, for me anyway, is keeping it under control so that everyone is not just sitting around looking at different devices." (P10).

While P10 voiced her negative opinion of using technology to entertain children, "it's just a way to get them to sit down and shut up, by distracting them with a screen" (P10), P9 described feeling "judged (by P10) on my abilities to parent. . . and that its lazy parenting" (P9). Additionally, P10 believed that P9 spent too much of her time using technology while at home. P9 was aware of this and explained, "I don't feel judged about my own use of tech anyone apart from P10. . . because she hates it" (P9). These stories suggest that P9 and P10's differing values can lead to them to make judgments that are, in turn, perceived as disapproval. Both parents acknowledged that this judgement and disapproval frequently triggers conflict within their relationship. Given the associations they each drew between family technology use and judgements on parenting approaches, it was easy to imagine how technology use could become the contentious issue within their relationship that both P9 and P10 described.

**Misperceptions:** Sometimes, conflict between P9 and P10 is caused by their lack of awareness of one another's attitudes and practices, especially with regards to technology use. For example, when we initially interviewed this set of parents together, P10 immediately dismissed the idea of their children having their own smartphones. P9 was clearly surprised to hear this, instead, suggesting it was an inevitability that might even support some aspects of parenting. Later, in the same interview, P10 claimed that neither she nor P9 used social networking sites. P9 hesitantly contradicted her, "But. . . as someone who's home a lot with the kids, I have been surprised how much I rely on Facebook" (P9). This indicated a lack of awareness and assumptions within this set of parents about one another's attitudes and practices surrounding technology use,

which were confirmed when we interviewed P9 and P10 on their own in the closing interviews.

Misperceptions could arise when parents were unaware of the reasons behind one another's differing individual attitudes to technology use, leading them to feel isolated or unsupported by each other. During our closing interviews, we learned how P9 had come to rely more on technology since becoming parent, owing to feelings of loneliness and a sense of "missing out on everything else", especially while P10 was working. As she explained her enthusiasm towards family technology use, she admitted to using technology "as a babysitter" and turning to her phone with "a feeling of hope" in an effort to distract herself from a sense of housebound isolation. She felt that P10, unable to understand this, frequently overruled her decisions on technology use in front of their children, and described this as an isolating experience as well. Meanwhile, P10 justified her stricter attitude towards their children's use of technology, by revealing that it was based on various fears, including those triggered by her upsetting experience of finding her young son watching inappropriate content online. She perceived P9 to have dismissed her fears, leaving her to manage their family's technology use alone, "It's frustrating and isolating. It would be more of a positive experience if it felt like something we were united on." (P10).

This lack of awareness between parents, and the resulting misperceptions, judgements or disapproval, can lead to parents not only feeling alone and unsupported, but also resentful of each other. With P9 and P10, we saw that this resentment can build up over time and eventually culminate in conflict. Both P9 and P10 mentioned that another source of resentment came from compromising on aspects of family technology use. For instance, P9 revealed that despite wanting to share photos of her children on Facebook, she reluctantly resisted out of consideration for P10's privacy concerns. On the other hand, P10 expressed that she regularly suppressed

her dislike at returning from work to find all her family members engaged in technology use.

We observed that conflicts over technology use had become such an accepted part of everyday family life that it often went unnoticed. P9 recognized the extent to which technology use contributed to family conflict, “I wasn’t aware how much conflict (over technology use) was taking up my energy” (P9). We also noticed that both P9 and P10 seemed relieved at having discovered some of the misperceptions and misunderstandings they had about one another’s attitudes towards family technology use. For instance, when P9 reflected on what she had learned about P10’s feelings she said, “I was surprised by that, and I guess doing this study gave me a legitimate lens to have a look at it” (P9). This might suggest that within the ‘everyday chaos’ of the family life described by P9 and P10, they might not usually find opportunities to share, communicate and negotiate their individual attitudes on technology use with one another in a rational manner.

Overall, P9 and P10’s responses offer insights into how differing parenting values and misperceptions of one another’s attitudes towards family technology use can foster ongoing conflict within sets of parents. We now turn to a second set of parents, to provide an example of other key factors that enable family technology use to contribute to conflict, and how this plays out within everyday life.

## 4.2 Imbalance and Inconsistency

P7 (39yrs) and P8 (42yrs) are a married couple raising their two daughters, aged fifteen and three. They described themselves as an aspirational, yet time-poor family, who often found everyday life to be tiring and tense. Despite P7 working four days a week as an engineering draftsman, she is relied upon as the children’s primary caregiver, and to manage most aspects of domestic life. Meanwhile, P8 focuses on running his IT company, which involves regular business travel.

This set of parents described how patterns of technology use within family life gradually contributed to growing tensions within their relationship. We saw that when these tensions built up over time, they eventually culminated in conflict between P7 and P8. We now explain the different ways in which this can play out in their relationship.

**Imbalance:** We found that apparent imbalance in the way in responsibilities are distributed within P7 and P8’s relationship might encourage technology to be used in ways that can foster tension and conflict between them. Specifically, P8 regularly spends long periods of time alone, on his personal devices, while P7 is left to continue with domestic chores and attending to their children while. P8 described how his habit of spending most of his evenings watching Netflix on his laptop developed as a way to unwind, “I’m addicted. . . the only way to switch off after work is to put my headphones on and isolate myself from everything. . .” (P8). P8 also mentioned that his wife, P7, strongly dislikes this behavior yet, we found that he was not fully aware of the reasons behind this.

While technology use is how P8 unwinds from his daily stresses at work, for P7, it reminds her of the uneven distribution of their parenting responsibilities, where she is responsible for a much greater share of parenting and domestic duties than he is. P7 explained that she also used to enjoy watching movies in the evening with her

husband, but that since having children, she had become too busy to join him, “to be honest, there’s no free time for me anymore” (P7). P7 revealed that while she tolerates the way that P8 regularly uses technology on his own, she does find his behavior to be excessive and selfish. She described feeling like it also allowed him to disengage from her; “with his Netflix, laptop on his lap, headphones on, that’s it, he’s out. Even if I talk to him he can’t hear it. I have to come to him, to nudge him.” (P7). She went on to describe how his habit prevents their children from engaging with him, thus makes them more even reliant on her for attention. At the same time, P8 admitted feeling guilty for wasting time that could be better spent with his daughters.

P7 acknowledged feeling jealous of P8’s preoccupation with technology, and expressed her desire to spend more time with him. Finally, she revealed the tension that builds up between them over the course of the week, and how this often culminates in conflict, “*our only free time together is Saturday and Sunday, but by then we’ll be lucky if there wasn’t a fight between us. . . then everyone’s tense, we don’t talk and we just start again on Monday*” (P7). Both parents agreed that the way in which P8 regularly uses technology alone disengages them from one another and is therefore detrimental to their relationship. P8 said he had tried to reduce the amount of time he spent alone on his devices. But, at the same time, he still maintained his need to unwind after a stressful day at work, and that technology promised him with the most convenient means to do this. This lure of technology, to provide personal entertainment as described by P8, can encourage technology practices to form that allow parents to disengage from one another. We see that when parents regularly use their devices in this way, it can amplify existing imbalance in relationships, causing tensions to grow over time and eventually creating conflict in parents’ relationships.

**Inconsistency:** P8’s habit of using technology to unwind and entertain himself while at home with his family also compounds the difficulties P7 and P8 already have in agreeing on, and enforcing, rules around their children’s device use. Both parents agreed that ideally, they would prefer their daughters to spend less time using screen-based devices. Yet, P7 explained that she sometimes found it helpful to relax technology rules, especially to make aspects of domestic life easier and less stressful. For instance, she described allowing her younger daughter to use an iPad while she prepared dinner, or to allow her daughter to play with a smartphone while drying her hair. On the other hand, P8 claimed that relaxing rules and using technology to placate his daughter in this way reflected badly on their parenting, “*we put our daughter on there to watch something when we are lazy and become bad parents*” (P8). However, hearing P8’s opinion prompted P7 to highlight the inconsistency between his expectations of his daughter’s behaviour and the behaviour that he role-models to them by regularly watching Netflix alone, on his laptop with his headphones. Furthermore, P7 feels especially justified in relaxing technology rules to afford her the peace and quiet to tend to the domestic chores and household routines that she is left to deal with alone, while P8 uses his devices. In such a situation, we could see how P8’s requests for P7 to uphold technology rules appeared hypocritical and frustrating to P7.

P8 admitted having difficulty reconciling his own use of technology with his parenting views, “*I know it might not be the healthiest habit, yet I’m giving it to my daughter*” (P8). He expressed his

guilt at having failed to break his habit, but conceded apathetically that, *"I'm too lazy (to stop) because I'm too tired from working 10 hours a day and I just want to switch off"*. He also perceived his own technology over-use to be part of a wider problem in society, in which people's dependency on technology use created a challenge within family life, *"balancing the relationship of the family over the needs of the individuals - it's a struggle, we try, try, try and fail."* (P8). We observed that existing tensions between P7 and P8 over how to mediate their daughters' technology use, are particularly exacerbated by the inconsistency between P8's own overt use of personal devices, and his stricter parenting views on how children should use technology. We saw that such inconsistency can contribute towards tensions and conflict in P7 and P8's relationship.

## 5 DISCUSSION

Our findings confirm that family technology use has the potential to negatively affect the relationships of parents who are raising children together. We have revealed four key factors that were found to enable technology use to create conflict between two exemplar sets of parents, and how this played out within their everyday lives. We now discuss how our findings might relate to parents in general and suggest directions of future work that to address the conflict that parents associate with technology use.

When parents have (i) *different parenting values* they might have differing individual expectations of how their family uses technology. This can lead to each parent setting different rules around technology use and/or enforcing them to varying extents. We have demonstrated that tension and conflict can then arise between parents who disapprove of the different ways in which they each manage their children's technology use.

Our findings also demonstrated that parents might have (ii) *mis-perceptions* about one another's towards family technology use. This can lead to parents making incorrect assumptions about each other's actions and lead to misunderstandings between parents. This can create conflict between parents and lead to tensions in their relationship because they feel unsupported by one another, and alone in their efforts to manage their children's technology use.

We revealed that (iii) *imbalance* in parents' relationships can encourage parents to use technology in ways that actually amplify this existing imbalance. For instance, domestic work was unevenly distributed between P7 and P8, and this allowed P8 to spend a lot of time alone on his personal devices, disengaging from his family. In turn, this reminded P7 of the fact that domestic work was not shared equally, and led to her feelings of frustration. This contributed towards tensions in P7 and P8's relationship that culminated in conflict between them. This supports McDaniel et al.'s [24] suggestions about the potential for parents to use technology in ways that lower their relationship quality.

Our example of P7 and P8's differing attitudes might support suggestions that traditional gender norms can help to explain differences in how parents utilize technology [4, 21]. While HCI's tendency to study mothers and fathers separately provides valuable glimpses into how they might manage family technology use differently [2, 3, 5], our initial results show that more work is needed to understand how sets of parents do this together.

Parents use technology extensively at home, while at the same time attempting to manage their children's technology use. We found that (iv) *inconsistency* between a parent's own behavior, and the expectations they set out around how their family should use technology can contribute towards tension and conflict between parents. This is because parents look to one another to provide positive role-modelling for their children, and can feel undermined, and less supported by each other when messaging around technology use is inconsistent.

*Contexts of Technology Use.* Parenting is usually a collaborative endeavor, and when parents have very different individual attitudes on how one should manage children's technology use and/or on how one should use technology (especially in front of children), we see that family technology use can indeed become a contentious issue within parents' relationships [1, 11, 24]. Our findings indicate that whether or not a particular use of technology leads to tension and conflict between parents depends on a variety of contextual considerations such as what device is being used, by whom, where, with who else present, how often, and for what purpose. While this aligns with findings of previous work on parent-child relationships [18, 35], we require further work to examine in more detail, how these contexts of technology use can contribute towards conflict between parents.

*One-Off Instances of Technology Use vs. Recurrent Behavior.* Our findings indicate that one-off instances involving technology use can lead directly to arguments between parents, or instead, recurring behavior might contribute over time to growing tensions that eventually lead to conflict. We observed that parents make comparisons, assumptions and judgements about how they each use technology use, and how they each manage their children's technology use. When it comes to parents disapproving of each other's technology use, it seems more likely that recurrent behavior contributes to disengagement, resentment, frustrations that grow over time and build to eventually result in conflict. On the other hand, one-off instances involving children's technology use are more likely to directly lead to disagreements between parents about how to manage them. We acknowledge that more work is needed to verify these observations.

*Lack of Opportunities to Communicate.* Overall, our findings demonstrate that within the messiness of everyday life, parents lack opportunities, a framework or even a language with which to calmly and constructively communicate and negotiate upon their individual perspective towards technology use. Given that conflict between parents over technology use can be detrimental to their overall relationship, and parenting satisfaction [24], we strongly encourage further work to explore how we might assist sets of parents in regularly reflecting on, and sharing their views on family technology use with one another. This would be a valuable enterprise, especially since parents need to constantly adapt their attitudes to consider growing children and the adoption of ever-evolving technologies [10].

## 6 CONCLUSIONS

Our work found four key factors that could enable family technology use to create conflict in parents' relationships. By exploring how family technology use affects parents' relationships, it complements current understandings of conflict in parent-child relationships [8, 16, 18], thus helping to create a more complete picture

of how technology use can impact on family dynamics. This work demonstrates that a variety of contextual factors determine whether or not technology use might lead to conflict between parents. It also reveals that one-off instances of technology use can trigger conflict between parents, and that recurrent technology use can cause tensions to accumulate over time within their relationships. The issues raised within this work suggest a need for further exploration of how sets of parents work together to manage their family's use of technology. In particular, we need to examine strategies that might help parents to better communicate and negotiate on their individual attitudes on family technology use. Overall, our results indicate that design opportunities exist to address the conflict that parents report is created within their relationships, as a result of family technology use.

NB. Future work should also consider any potential effects that the COVID-19 pandemic might have had on how parents have had to adapt their attitudes and practices regarding family technology use, as this work was conducted before these were fully felt.

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